4. Roads serve as a feeder lines and help in the development of other means of communication.
5. They facilitate communication on land.
6. Natural resources of an area can be tapped and improved.
7. Roads help to increase the land value enroute.
8. Roads aid good medical facilities to reach everyone.
9. They provide good commercial links between cities.
10. The improvement of highway system increases the mail facilities.

6.2 Highway Development and Planning

6.2.1 Highway Development in India

Roads in Ancient India

The excavation of Mohenjo-daro and Harappa have exposed the existence of roads in India even 3500 years B.C. Kautilya, the first prime minister of Emperor Chandra Gupta Maurya, wrote a book 'Artha Shastra". In that book he mentioned the specifications for road width, road surfaces, traffic control, etc. King Ashoka constructed a good network of roads during 269 B.C., where trees were planted on either side of the roads for giving shade to the travellers and the rest houses were provided at a distance of about 5 – 7 km along the road for the comfort and convenience of the tired travellers.

Roads in Mughal Period

During Mughal period, the Muslim rulers improved the roads of India to a great extent which received high appreciation from the foreign visitors who visited India at that period. 24 long roads connecting distant towns and cities were constructed during Mughal period.

Roads during British rule

In 1865 Lord Dalhousie, the Governor-General formed the Public Works Department in more or less the same format that exists today.

Jayakar Committee

Jayakar Committee was formed in 1927 to investigate and report about the existing roads and the road development in the country. A central road organisation was set up in 1930 and in 1935 a transport committee was formed.

Nagpur Plan

After 2nd World War, a conference of all the chief engineers of all the states and Provinces was convened by the central government on 15th December, 1943 at Nagpur on the recommendation of I.R.C. This was the first attempt to prepare a co-ordinated road development programme in a planned manner. This conference prepared the first 20-year road development plan and was popularly known as Nagpur plan. It drew the following conclusions:

1. To recommend an all Indian basis for geometric standards, highways and bridge specifications, road machinery and road organisations.
2. To classify all roads as National highways, State highways, District roads and Village roads.
3. To implement a balanced development of all classes of roads.
4. The Central government to take up the complete financial responsibility of all major roads.
5. The state government to take up the complete financial responsibility of all other roads.

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